

NEW RESEARCH BRIEF

Does government communication build trust?

Two decades of peer-reviewed research says yes, with one big condition.

What the studies found, and what it means for the people who run the accounts.

THE FINDING

Residents who use their government's website and social media trust it more.



Established across national surveys and replicated for two decades.

Tolbert & Mossberger 2006 · Welch, Hinnant & Moon 2005

THE PATHWAY

The same chain shows up study after study.

Good communication

website · social media · responsiveness



Residents feel informed and heard

transparency · responsiveness



Trust, satisfaction, support

for the government and its work

Kim & Lee 2012 · Song & Lee 2016 · Tolbert & Mossberger 2006 ·
Welch et al. 2005

THE CONDITION

Done badly, it can run the other way.

Information dumped out poorly can lower trust. The same openness, delivered well, raises it.

A 2025 meta-analysis of 54 studies: a positive but modest effect that depends on how it's done.

Grimmelikhuijsen & Meijer 2014 · Porumbescu 2016 · Li, Wang & Qu 2025

PENSACOLA · FLORIDA

What “done well” looks like.



WHY IT WORKS

Not an announcement. A government sharing something residents already care about: a hometown American Idol contestant and a planned community concert.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW

Trust in information from local news



Pew Research Center

Your own channels are becoming residents' main source of civic information. The framing, timing, responsiveness, and judgment are the job.

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